MIDNIGHT VERB

16 BIT DIGITAL EFFECTS PROCESSOR

User Manual

Overview

Midnight Verb models three Alesis rack units from the mid-1980s: the MidiVerb (1985), MidiFex (1986), and MidiVerb II (1986). All 228 factory effect programs are included - reverbs, gates, reverse, delays, chorus, flange and stereo effects - running the original algorithms. Added on top: pre-delay, tone, a lowpass, stereo width, input-driven ducking, variable program size, a switchable device clock, and a vintage analog signal chain.

Signal Flow

Modern mode:

Input → Tone → Pre-delay → Effect Algorithm → Lowpass → Width → Ducking → Mix → Output

Vintage mode:

Input → Tone → Pre-delay → analog input filters → Effect Algorithm → analog output filter → Lowpass → Width → Ducking → Mix → Output

Main Controls

Parameter	Description
Effect	Master bypass switch (Off/On). When Off, the plugin passes dry signal only.
Character	Modern: the digital effect on its own. Vintage: adds the analog input and output stages of the original hardware - a resonant lowpass around 13kHz, a highpass at 31Hz, and a filter on the output. Subtle, but it is the colour of the box.
Pre-delay	Delay before the effect begins (0–250ms). Adds separation between the dry signal and the effect tail, the classic trick for keeping a reverb from crowding the source. Click the metronome above the knob to switch it to note values instead, from 1/64 up to 1/2 with dotted and triplet variants, locked to the host tempo. The knob changes to the note list when you do.
Tone	Tilts the effect between dark and bright (0–100%). 50% is flat. Below 50% the highs come down, above 50% the lows come down. It only ever cuts, never boosts, so it cannot push the effect into overload. Active in both Modern and Vintage modes.
Mix	Wet/dry balance (0–100%). At 100% only the effect signal is output. At 0% the signal is fully dry. Default is 100% for use on send/return buses.
Size	Scales the program's delay times (25–175%). 100% is the hardware's own timing, and sits at the centre of the knob. On the flange and chorus programs it scales the LFO depth instead - the same thing there, since the LFO output is the delay length.
Clock	Runs the emulated device faster or slower (0.5x–2x). Down is longer and darker, up is shorter and brighter. 1x is the hardware rate.
Width	Stereo width of the effect signal (0–200%). 100% leaves it unaltered; 0% collapses it to mono.

LFO Rate	Speed of the internal LFO (10–400%), where 100% is the hardware rate. Appears only on the MidiVerb II flange and chorus programs; on every other program this place on the panel is taken by Lowpass.
Lowpass	Rolls the top off the effect (0–100%), fully open at 100%. Good for sitting a bright reverb further back without dulling the dry signal. The knob is scaled by ear, so the centre sits around 5kHz. Shares its place on the panel with LFO Rate, so you will see it on the reverb and delay programs.
Pre-delay Sync	The metronome next to Pre-delay. Off, the knob is in milliseconds. On, it becomes a list of note divisions and follows your session tempo, so the pre-delay stays in time if you change the tempo later. If your host reports no tempo, it stays on the millisecond value.

Ducking Controls

Parameter	Description
Duck Time	Release time for the effect to return after ducking (10–500ms). Shorter times = effect comes back quickly. Longer times = smoother, more gradual swell.
Duck Sens	Sensitivity of the ducking detector (0–100%). Higher values make ducking trigger on quieter signals. Increase it on a send/return bus, where input levels are lower.
Duck Amount	Intensity of ducking effect (0–100%). At 0%, ducking is disabled. Higher values duck the effect more aggressively when input signal is present.

Effect Models

MidiVerb (1985) - 64 Programs

The original Alesis MidiVerb was one of the first affordable digital reverb processors. All 64 programs are reverb-focused, organized by decay time from 0.2 seconds up to 20 seconds. Includes small, medium, and large room sizes with bright, warm, and dark tonal variations. Programs 51–59 provide gated reverb effects (100–600ms), and programs 60–63 offer reverse reverb (300–600ms). Program 64 is Defeat, which passes the input through unaltered.

MidiFex (1986) - 64 Programs

The Alesis MidiFex was a dedicated delay and effects processor. Its 64 programs cover single echoes (short to long with HPF/BPF/LPF filtering), 2-tap and 3-tap delays with panning and ambience, regenerating delays, slap echoes, reverb hybrids, multitap effects, thickeners, and stereo generation effects. Programs 37–42 (REGEN) are the repeating delays; the ECHO programs give a single repeat. Program 64 is Defeat, which passes the input through unaltered.

MidiVerb II (1986) - 100 Programs

The MidiVerb II expanded on the original with 100 programs across seven categories:

Reverb (Programs 0–29): 30 reverb programs from small bright rooms (0.1s) to extra-large warm halls (15s). Program 0 is Defeat, which passes the input through unaltered.

Gate (Programs 30–39): 10 gated reverb programs with slow and fast gate characteristics (75–450ms).

Reverse (Programs 40–49): 10 reverse reverb and bloom effects (150ms–8s), including regenerating reverse programs.

Flange (Programs 50–59): 10 flange programs including triggered flanges and stereo panning flanges. These use the internal LFO.

Chorus (Programs 60–69): 10 chorus programs from light to deep, plus fast chorus. These use the internal LFO.

Delay (Programs 70–89): 20 delay programs with fixed delay times from 35ms to 460ms.

EFX (Programs 90–99): 10 special effects including multi-tap, stereo generation, thickener, and regenerating delays (2–4s).

Front Panel

Display - shows what is loaded: the model, the program number and its name, for example MV-2 67 Deep Chorus 3. Presets from the Midnight folder show their own name instead, since the program alone would not tell you which one you picked.
Metronome - sits above the Pre-delay knob. Click it to swap Pre-delay between milliseconds and note values. It lights when sync is on.
SIGNAL - lights when audio is reaching the plugin.
OVLD - lights when the effect is being driven past what it can take, and holds long enough that a single peak is visible. Like the lamp on the original hardware it watches the input, so it can light even with Mix at 0%. If it flickers, turn your send down.

Presets

Midnight Verb includes 228 factory presets organized in folders matching the three hardware models. MidiVerb II presets are further organized into subcategories (Reverb, Gate, Reverse, Flange, Chorus, Delay, EFX). Each preset sets the correct model and program number, with all other parameters at default values so you can use them as starting points for your own tweaks. A second bank, Insert 30% Mix, holds every preset again with Mix at 30% for use directly on a track rather than on a send. A third folder, Midnight, holds ten MNV presets, mirrored in the 30% bank as well, that are not from the hardware at all – they take the longer programs and push them with the controls the original machines never had: size, lowpass, clock, tempo-synced pre-delay and the vintage filters.

Model and Program are set by the presets and are not on the front panel. Both remain available to host automation if you want to sweep programs - Model selects MV-1, MFX or MV-2, and Program runs 0–63 on MV-1 and MFX, 0–99 on MV-2. Note that MV-1 and MFX number their programs from 1 on the display, as the hardware did, so the automation value is always one lower than the number you see.

Quick Start

Lush hall reverb: MidiVerb II / Reverb / 21 Large Warm 2.2s, Mix 40–60%, Pre-delay 30–50ms, or click the metronome and pick 1/32

Small room ambience: MidiVerb / 01 Small Bright 0.2s, Mix 25–40%

Classic 80s gated drums: MidiVerb II / Gate, any program, Mix 60–80%

Echo and delay: the MidiFex bank. The Echo programs give a single repeat, the Regen programs repeat

Chorus and flange: MidiVerb II / Chorus or Flange, Mix 30–50%

Stereo widening: MidiFex / 60–63 StereoGen, Mix 50–70%

Vintage character: set Character to Vintage for the analog colouration of the original

Keeping the dry signal clear: any effect, Duck Amount 50–70%, Duck Time 100–200ms

On a send: Mix 100% (default). Straight on a track: load from the Insert 30% Mix bank instead

Noise Gate

Midnight Verb includes an automatic noise gate that activates after 16 seconds of silence, fading the wet signal to zero over 6 seconds. This prevents the emulated 16-bit noise floor from being audible during quiet passages. The gate resets immediately when new input signal is detected.

Technical Notes

Midnight Verb runs the original effect algorithms from the Alesis hardware, and each model runs at its own sample rate just as the machines did: 23.4kHz on the MidiVerb and MidiFex, 31.25kHz on the MidiVerb II. That difference is audible - for the same setting the MidiVerb II is the brighter machine and its programs are shorter. Converter depth follows the hardware too: 13-bit on the MidiVerb and MidiFex, 16-bit on the MidiVerb II. Everything is computed in 16-bit whole numbers over a shared 16K memory, which means the effect can be overdriven exactly as the hardware could - that is what the OVLD lamp is watching.

Vintage mode adds the analog input and output stages of the MidiVerb II, based on John Googler Brombaugh’s analysis of the service manual schematics:

• a resonant 13kHz lowpass, which lifts the region around 8.5kHz

• a 31Hz highpass

• an 11kHz filter on the output

MidiVerb II programs 50–69 (flange and chorus) use an internal LFO. Size sets how deep it sweeps and LFO Rate how fast; at 100% both match the original per-program settings. On every other program those two controls are replaced by Lowpass.

Support

For technical support, updates, and additional information:

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